

Bring Your Own Problem (BYOP): BYOP Clinic 1: Define the Problem and Decision

Structure for Defining a Health Systems Problem

1. Decision-Maker: Identify who has the authority or responsibility to make a decision about the problem.

- Who needs to make the decision?
- What level of the health system are they operating at?
 - National
 - Regional
 - District
 - Facility/community
- What decisions are within their control?

Example: *District Health Management Team responsible for planning and allocating health resources.*

2. Problem: Clearly describe what is going wrong or what decision needs to be addressed.

- What is the specific health systems problem?
- What evidence shows that it is a problem?
- How large or important is the problem?
- What are the possible causes or contributing factors?

Example: *Low utilization of maternal health services despite the availability of health facilities, potentially contributing to poor maternal and neonatal outcomes.*

3. Population: Define who is affected by the problem.

Consider:

- Age
- Sex
- Socioeconomic characteristics
- Geographic location
- Vulnerable or high-risk groups

Example: *Pregnant women of reproductive age living in rural communities within the district.*

4. Place: Specify where the problem occurs.

This could include:

- Country
- Region
- District
- Community
- Health facility
- Urban or rural setting

Example: *Selected rural communities and primary healthcare facilities in the district.*

5. Period: Define the time period during which the problem is being considered.

- When did the problem occur?
- Is it ongoing?
- What period will be used to assess the problem?

Example: *January 2024–December 2025.*

6. Intended Action: State what decision or action is expected as a result of defining and analyzing the problem. The action should be practical and within the decision-maker's authority.

Examples include:

- Reallocate resources
- Increase staffing
- Improve service delivery
- Introduce an intervention
- Strengthen health information systems
- Improve supply-chain management
- Develop a new policy or programme

Example: *Determine whether additional resources, community outreach, or improvements in service delivery are required to increase maternal health service utilization.*

7. Link the Problem to the Health System:

After completing the Decision Canvas, explicitly identify which components of the health system contribute to or are affected by the problem. For example:

- **Health workforce:** availability, distribution, skills, workload
- **Service delivery:** accessibility, quality, continuity, responsiveness
- **Health information systems:** availability and quality of data
- **Medicines and technologies:** availability and supply chains
- **Health financing:** funding, affordability, resource allocation
- **Leadership and governance:** policies, accountability and coordination

8. Obtain Peer Feedback:

Finally, share the completed Decision Canvas with colleagues or stakeholders and ask them to assess:

1. Is the problem clearly stated?
2. Is the problem specific enough?
3. Is the decision-maker appropriate?
4. Is the affected population clearly defined?
5. Is the place and period sufficiently specific?
6. Is the intended action realistic?
7. Is the link to the health system clear?
8. What important information or perspective is missing?

Key principle: A well-defined health systems problem should ultimately connect
a specific decision-maker → a clearly defined problem → an affected population → a specific place and period → an actionable decision,
while showing how the problem relates to the functioning of the health system.